



Striving for Thriving: A Narrative Analysis of Cyclists' Stories From the Olympic Qualification Window

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Our purpose for the present study was to understand elite track cyclists' stories of attempting to experience thriving during an Olympic qualification window. More specifically, we hoped to describe the narratives underpinning the cyclists' stories during this time and to gain an understanding of the sociocultural factors that were perceived to influence their experiences. Interviews were conducted with eleven elite track cyclists on three occasions over a 6-month period. Interview data were analyzed using a combination of holistic-form structural analysis and thematic narrative analysis. Our results are presented as a realist tale and illustrate three narratives: *performance*, *discovery*, and *vindication*. We interpreted the results to suggest that the *performance* narrative was prominent and drawn on within many, if not all, athletes' stories. Our results show that, although aspirations exist in research and practice to dilute the prevailing *performance* narrative with one that provides a frame for concurrent experiences of sporting success and athlete well-being (i.e., thriving), attempts to make this shift will likely be complex. These findings are the first representation of athlete stories as they attempt to experience thriving during a critical part of their Olympic journey and offer a unique insight into the narratives that inform their stories. Moreover, they highlight the important sociocultural factors for supporting thriving in people and systems at the highest level of sport.

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Narratives are the templates that cultures make available for people to tell their own stories (cf. Frank, 1995) and make sense of their experiences. The performance narrative, first described by Douglas and Carless in 2006, reflects a template that places winning and success as the primary objectives of sport participation. The presence of this narrative has been repeatedly noted in academic literature (e.g., Carless & Douglas, 2013; Douglas & Carless, 2009; Franck & Stambulova, 2019) and is reflected in policy documentation

(e.g., UK Sport, 2004). One could argue that, by embracing the performance narrative, individuals within elite sport have enhanced professional standards, driven investment, and some have, ultimately, achieved greater sporting success. Yet, athletes who embrace or draw on the performance narrative subscribe to a belief that they must dedicate themselves to their training, preparation, and competition at the expense of other areas of their lives. In so doing they become exposed to risks of ill-being when their performance

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levels fail to reach the requisite standard, when sustaining an injury, and when retiring from sport (Barker-Ruchti et al., 2019; Douglas & Carless, 2009). Moreover, at a systemic level, a dominant performance narrative reflects the “need” for successful sport organizations, which has, in some sport environments, fostered a “win-at-all-costs” mentality (e.g., Dodge & Robertson, 2004). Given the dominance of the performance narrative in elite sport, Douglas and Carless (2006) argued for the need to hear, understand, and represent stories in the academic literature that provide alternative narratives that demonstrate success can be achieved without adhering to this prevailing perspective; these alternatives, they purport, are “in the interests of both performance and well-being” (Douglas & Carless, 2006, p. 16).

Two alternative narratives that were originally described by Douglas and Carless (2006, 2015) were a discovery narrative and a relational narrative. The discovery narrative described life histories that were focused on “discovering, experiencing, and exploring life in a full and multidimensional sense” (Douglas & Carless, 2006, p. 19), and the relational narrative encompassed a focus on the needs of others rather than the self and an emphasis on interpersonal dimensions (e.g., closeness and attachment). Since this early work, sport psychology researchers have documented several other nonperformance narratives that exist in high-level sport (e.g., Book et al., 2021; Carless & Douglas, 2013; Ronkainen & Ryba, 2020). For example, Book et al. (2021) described how *sink or swim* narratives were prominent in the stories of two African American professional athletes from the United States and Ronkainen and Ryba (2020) documented a *lifestyle athlete* narrative in Finnish preelite athletes’ future-oriented identities. Indeed, across this literature, scholars have argued that the performance narrative may not be as all-consuming as initially purported (Ronkainen & Ryba, 2020) and that success can and has been achieved in elite sport without subscribing to it (e.g., Carless & Douglas, 2013).

In addition to the documentation of alternative narratives within academic literature, attempts are being made through elite sport policy and practice to replace the performance narrative with a socio-cultural template that emphasizes the importance of athlete welfare and well-being alongside performance. To illustrate, within the United Kingdom, UK Sport (the governmental body responsible for distributing funding to sport national governing

bodies) has shifted their discourse from one which advocated “no compromise” to “winning well” and sports are now required to document the steps they have taken to protect athlete welfare (see, Wagstaff & Quartiroli, 2023). In tandem, organizations providing science and medicine support within British elite sport have been guided by agendas that forefront well-being alongside performance to promote thriving (see, Passaportis et al., 2022, 2024). More broadly, elite sport systems across the globe are attending to the dominant narratives that have previously influenced their actions to foster more sustainable and safe sporting environments (e.g., Australian High Performance Sport System, 2022; Sport Canada, 2019), and practitioners continue to advocate for the centrality of athlete mental health in elite sport (e.g., Henriksen et al., 2020). In sum, it is clear that steps are being taken to try to shift the priorities, expected norms, and messaging within elite sport organizations to support a new template that may alter the dominant narrative from one that solely privileges winning, to one which also prioritizes well-being.

Within sport contexts, the concurrent experience of sustained high-level performance and dimensions of well-being (e.g., being focused and in control, having a sense of belonging) has been described as characterizing thriving (Brown et al., 2018). Moreover, thriving has been used to label athletes (Brown, Arnold, Standage, & Fletcher, 2017) and coaches (McNeill et al., 2018) who self-report high levels of subjective performance and well-being. This work aligns with the theoretical perspective that thriving occurs when individuals are functioning fully and holistically (Brown, Arnold, Fletcher, & Standage, 2017; Ryan & Deci, 2017; Su et al., 2014), with performance and well-being considered context-relevant markers of functioning (Brown et al., 2024). According to this perspective, thriving is defined as “the joint experience of development and success” (Brown, Arnold, Fletcher, & Standage, 2017, p. 168),¹ and reflects humans’ innate drive for growth and self-improvement (i.e., development) combined with a need to achieve context-relevant outcomes (i.e., success).

Building from this understanding, researchers have started to identify a range of intrapersonal

¹ For a discussion of alternative theoretical perspectives and definitions of thriving, and consideration of thriving with related constructs (e.g., resilience, growth), please see Brown, Arnold, Fletcher, and Standage (2017), Brown, Sarkar, and Howells (2021), and Brown et al. (2024).

(e.g., resilient qualities) and interpersonal (e.g., secure attachment) factors that predict thriving, as well as speculating on the organizational influences that may be pertinent to thriving being experienced (e.g., organizational norms; see, for a review, Brown et al., 2024). To illustrate with evidence from the highest level of sport performers, Brown and Arnold (2019) described professional rugby players' desire to operate within an integrated, inclusive, and trusting environment and that their thriving was contingent on strong bonds with teammates and fostering a meaningful connection to coaching staff and the club. More recently, Passaportis et al. (2022) documented the attempts of a British Olympic and Paralympic sport organization to promote thriving through an organization-wide commitment to relationships governed by understanding, openness, and trust. Altogether, these findings are helping to inform the creation of *thriving environments*; that is, spaces where individuals are supported to achieve their performance outcomes in a safe, sustainable, and fulfilled way to, ultimately, experience development and success. Despite these recent advances to thriving theory and the desired shift toward a narrative that advocates for well-being and performance in elite sport, it has been suggested that a dominant narrative can supplant and silence alternative (or emerging) narratives in a given situation and context (Douglas & Carless, 2006). Thus, there may be occasions when the performance narrative reemerges as the predominate perspective.

Central to the experiences of athletes and personnel involved in Olympic and Paralympic sports is both their preparation for and experience of the Games. Focusing on the preparation for the Games, researchers have reported on the challenges athletes and coaches experience during the immediate lead up to the Games (Dehghansai et al., 2021), and on the impact of the associated psychological stress on sleep quality (Halson et al., 2022), illness and energy levels (Drew et al., 2018). Further, using a longer window of inquiry, Mitchell et al. (2021) and Zamora-Solé et al. (2024) explored athletes' attempts to qualify for the Games, considering the transitional demands experienced and the meaning-making of non-qualification, respectively. Collectively, the demands experienced during this preparatory phase may reassert performance-based priorities and messaging at the expense of a dual well-being and performance focus, impacting the stories told by athletes at this time. It follows that the narratives

that exist in athletes' stories as they attempt to experience thriving during this window are salient. Indeed, the insights that can be gained from these narratives are critical for our understanding of the sociocultural factors that influence athletes and their stories, and for practitioners and sport organizations when attempting to support their athletes and staff to thrive during Games qualification.

The present study was conducted with the track cycling squad of an International Cycling Federation following an inquiry from one of their coaches. Track cycling has complex interpersonal dynamics with cyclists competing in a variety of sprint and endurance events, and, for the latter, this can be either as an individual (e.g., omnium), a dyad (e.g., Madison), or a team (e.g., team pursuit). Cyclists within the endurance squad can therefore be required to switch between contrient (i.e., compete individually, against one another, and with no identified group goal) and integrated (i.e., work together to achieve a common goal) events depending on the discipline they race in (cf. Evans et al., 2012). Our purpose for the study was to explore the elite track cyclists' stories of attempting to experience thriving during an Olympic qualification window. More specifically, we hoped to describe the narratives underpinning the cyclists' stories during this time and to gain an understanding of the sociocultural factors that were perceived to influence their experiences.

Method

Research Design

For this study, we adopted a critical realist positionality underpinned by ontological realism and epistemological constructivism, believing that there is a perceived reality (i.e., thriving), but that our pursuit of that reality may be incomplete or impossible. This stance meant that we were able to look at individual experiences of the "real" by exploring lived experiences and to develop deeper understanding of the narratives that were reflected in the stories told of that phenomenon. Specifically, it allowed us to understand the narratives that underpinned track cyclists' stories of attempting to experience thriving and the factors that furnished the narratives in these experiences. Within this study, participants were invited to share their stories in conversations with the first author, which were elicited through multiple semistructured interviews.

Participants

The sample for this study comprised eleven elite track racing cyclists aged between 20 and 28 years. They included male and female cyclists representing the same International Cycling Federation in either sprint or endurance disciplines. The cyclists received funding via their national funding body, professional team contracts, sponsorship, prize money, enrollment with their national military, family members, and/or regional benevolent funds. The participants had previously competed at Union Cycliste Internationale junior and elite levels for between two and 13 years, which included a combination of racing on the mountain, the road, and the track. At the time of the first interview, the cyclists had competed in 126 major sporting events (i.e., Continental Championships, World Championships, or Olympic Games) and won 36 medals at these events. During data collection, they were competing in track races classified by the Union Cycliste Internationale as Classes 1 and 2, Regional Games, Continental Championships, and World Championships, with some of the cyclists also racing on the Union Cycliste Internationale road WorldTour. This sample was deemed appropriate and sufficiently sized for the present study given the anticipated depth and breadth of the cyclists' attempts to experience thriving during the Olympic qualification window.

Data Collection

The project involved cyclist interviews being conducted three times over a 6-month period starting approximately 18-month out from the originally scheduled Tokyo Olympic Games. Following institutional ethical approval, proposed dates for the first data collection were established with the coaches of the International Cycling Federation to align with an upcoming training camp (May 2019). The athletes and first author were introduced at the camp by the coaches and the interviews ($n = 10$) were conducted on a one-to-one basis in a private room in the velodrome. Skype interviews were arranged with cyclists who were not attending the training camp but were interested in taking part. All interviews were conducted in English; yet, as this was not the cyclists' first language, time was taken prior to the interviews commencing to explain the purpose of the study and what it involved and to provide an

opportunity for the cyclists to ask any questions. The semistructured interviews were conducted using an interview guide that was designed to explore cyclists' experiences of thriving to date, as well as the sociocultural factors that may have characterized or shaped their attempts to experience thriving; the questioning on these factors was informed by previous studies in this area (e.g., Brown & Arnold, 2019; Brown et al., 2018). These interviews also provided the starting point for the cyclists' stories about their ongoing attempts to experience thriving during Olympic qualification. The interviews lasted between 47 and 69 min were digitally recorded in their entirety and transcribed in full.

The second ($n = 11$) and third ($n = 11$) sets of interviews were conducted at a competition and training camp 11–12 and 8 months prior to the games, respectively. The follow-up interviews afforded the researchers the opportunity to ask the cyclists about their experiences at different points during their race season and to explore how these may have changed from previous conversations. In so doing, these interviews enabled the cyclists to story how their experiences had evolved over time and thus provided insight into the narrative structure underpinning these stories. In addition, the second and third interviews allowed the researchers to engage in member reflections with the cyclists to further understand ideas raised in a previous interview and to hear their thoughts of aspects raised by some of the other cyclists (see, Smith & McGannon, 2018). Examples of topics added to the second interview included the cyclists' relationships with social media and the alignment of their and the training group's goals. The topics added to the third interview included the balance between solo and team training, leadership within the training group, and areas of good coaching practice. In total, over 28 hr of interview data were recorded.

Data Analysis

We conducted our analysis from the position of a storyanalyst (i.e., we placed the narratives under analysis; Smith, 2016) and employed two approaches. The first approach involved using holistic-form structural analysis (Lieblich et al., 1998; Smith, 2016) to identify the narratives that underpinned the cyclists' stories as they attempted to experience thriving during the Olympic qualification window. The second approach was

thematic narrative analysis (Riessman, 2008; Smith, 2016), which we used to explore the sociocultural factors that furnished the narratives in the stories. In a similar vein to the sentiments of Book et al. (2021), this process was complex, messy, cyclical, and often involved moving back and forth between steps.

Our approach began by following the steps for thematic narrative analysis and holistic-form structural analysis presented by Smith (2016). The longitudinal nature of data collected meant that interview data were transcribed, and initial analytical notes written between interview rounds. Transcription was outsourced to expedite transcript production, which meant that the first author was able to read, reflect, and note ongoing ideas and patterns he observed within and between participants' stories. Following transcription, the next analytical stage—narrative indwelling—involved the first author reading each cyclist's set of interviews in full several times along with the analytical notes he had made during data collection. Impressions about defining sociocultural features, patterns, and story plots within the cyclist's story were noted down and displayed within concept maps to highlight any potential shifts in the storyline or associations of interest. This process was repeated for each of the cyclists, with the first author simultaneously compiling ideas about potential patterns across the sample.

The impressions documented through narrative indwelling led to the preliminary identification of narrative themes and thematic relationships, which were then supplemented by returning to the transcripts and coding sections using both manifest (i.e., key details) and latent (i.e., underlying meaning) labels to highlight relevant sections of the transcripts. To describe and interpret the narrative themes, the first author reviewed the codes alongside his impressions of the key defining features. Simultaneous to thematic coding, the first author looked for clues within the data about how the stories were shaped (e.g., the direction of the story, participant's reflections on specific moments in their experience) and annotated transcripts with comments about the presence of storylines connecting moments in the qualification window. Ultimately, the codes and annotations were distilled into keywords or phrases describing structural features potentially indicative of the narrative (e.g., stories of vindication; stories that were stable, deteriorating) and themes describing key sociocultural patterns across the stories (e.g., friendship;

national identity). The keywords, themes, and their placement within initial narrative structures were then discussed and agreed with the second author during several collaborative analysis sessions.

At this stage, the first author began drafting descriptions of the narratives and returned to the coded transcripts to integrate data quotes from the cyclists' stories into these descriptions. The descriptions were not only intended to indicate the structure of the narrative but also to depict the sociocultural factors that furnished the narrative and influenced the cyclists' attempts to experience thriving. After each description had been created, these were shared and discussed with the second author, which resulted in further narrative refinement until both authors were satisfied. Once the authors were satisfied with the narrative names, descriptions, and the illustration of the key sociocultural features, they were presented as a realist tale in our results. These findings were shared with the cyclists and their coaches to seek reflections on their resonance, plausibility, and to ensure that they were satisfied that their identities were suitably protective; no changes were requested.

Research Quality

As adopting a critical realism positionality includes a methodological plurality, it falls to readers to judge the quality of this research in tandem with the methodological choices we have taken as researchers (Danermark et al., 2019). For the purposes of this study and in light of our methodological choices, we encourage the reader to consider the quality of our combined holistic-form structural analysis and thematic narrative analysis according to its meaningfulness of contribution, credibility, and resonance (see Hägglund et al., 2025; Middleton et al., 2025). To elaborate, we sought to promote meaningfulness of contribution by offering a novel and relevant insight to a worthy topic of thriving in elite sport. From a credibility perspective, our multiple interviews, inclusion of reflective notes, and member reflections were considered beneficial to the promotion of a credible process for developing the data. In turn, we have attempted to articulate the roles we played in acting as the conduits for collecting and representing data. Relatedly, we chose to represent our results in a way that would be resonant with readers and to also seek member reflections regarding the participants' and their coaches' perspectives on their resonance.

Researcher Reflections

Prior to presenting the results from this study, we believe that it is valuable to briefly share some reflections from the first author's experience conducting the interviews and constructing the findings. The reflections have been detailed at length in a journal that I, first author, maintained throughout the study, and include both practical, ethical, and analytical questioning, and details of events that have shaped and influenced my experience.

I began the study with limited knowledge of track cycling with my only experience as a fan watching cycling at the Olympic and Paralympic Games on television. I had knowledge of cyclists from my own country, but very little awareness beyond that. So, when I was approached by the coach about working together on this research, I was excited to learn about a new sport and to begin a new collaboration.

On my first day in the velodrome, I was anxious to make a good impression and to start to build relationships with the coaches and cyclists. I sensed an unease as we sat having lunch. In part, I think this was because I was unable to speak the cyclists' and coaches' first language and so relied on them to converse in English but also because I was unfamiliar with their customs and values. As time passed, both on that first day and for the duration of the project, I felt grateful for the openness and warmth that the coaches and cyclists showed me. Given the repeated interviews were predominantly conducted in-person at training camps and competitions, I was able to develop a good rapport and friendly disposition with the cyclists, and the opportunity to build a deep understanding of their experiences. These interactions meant I was better informed and allowed for a more relaxed atmosphere during interviews, which I believe enhanced the depth and richness of cyclist storytelling.

When conducting the interviews, it became apparent that some of the English language used in the interview guide, including the word *thriving*, was not familiar to the participants. As such, I chose to reword the questions to use vocabulary that was more accessible (e.g., high performance and well-being). I believe this decision was pragmatic and enabled interviews to continue, but it also meant that there are very limited data quotations that explicitly mention thriving. For a reader, this may create a disconnect between the stated purpose of the study (i.e., to explore cyclists' attempts to

experience thriving) and the results and, as an author, this has confronted an ideal I hold about having a neat "thread" throughout an article. Through working closely with my coauthor and reflecting with the constructive comments provided by reviewers, I hope that we have constructed a transparent and coherent article.

Throughout the study, I have held a strong view about the importance of culturally responsive relational ethics (Palmer, 2016) and the need to remain vigilant to the risk of the research destabilizing the interpersonal relationships (e.g., coach-athlete) and overall functioning of the organization. When preparing the results, my coauthor and I consulted a peer (acting as a critical friend) to inform decisions to exclude or minimize focus on some aspects described by the cyclists to protect their identities. I was also eager to employ member reflections and postconsent to ensure that the cyclists and their coaches agreed to the data being included in the internal and public research reports (see Smith & McGannon, 2018) and that they were satisfied with the level of risk from deductive disclosure (i.e., being revealed by the details included in the data; Kaiser, 2009). Employing these strategies enabled me to maintain the trust that the participants had afforded me.

Transparency and Openness Statement

Due to the nature of this research, participants in this study did not agree to the data being shared publicly, so supporting data (i.e., transcripts) are not available. Some participant details have also been withheld to protect the cyclists' identities. The study, research questions, and analysis plan were not preregistered. The interview guides can be accessed via the [Supplemental Materials](#).

Results

In keeping with the aims of this study, the following results section includes a realist tale of the narratives that underpin the stories described by the cyclists in their attempts to experience thriving during the Tokyo Olympic Games qualification window. These narratives include the ubiquitous presence of the *performance* narrative, along with two alternative narratives labeled *discovery* and *vindication*. We identified the *performance* narrative by stories that described or displayed the single-minded dedication to sport performance, the *discovery* narrative by stories

that described or displayed a focus on learning or realizing something new from an experience, and the *vindication* narrative by stories that described or displayed a want or need to prove oneself in the eyes of others. Within the presentation of each narrative, we have used quotes from the interview transcripts and described the sociocultural factors that were perceived to influence the cyclists' experiences. In our representation of the results, we have also attempted to describe how the stories evolved and shifted over time (i.e., the three rounds of interviews) to convey, where appropriate, the temporality in the narratives.

Performance

It was evident from the cyclists' stories that the *performance* narrative played at least some part in all their attempts to experience thriving. While some of the cyclists appeared to fully subscribe to this narrative, others wrestled with it as it created demands and pressures and conflicted with the alternative narratives they wanted to adopt. The *performance* narrative was reflected in the single-mindedness and businesslike approach embodied by some of the cyclists when describing their expectations of self and others, "everybody has [their] job and they just have to do the job, not more, not less." Moreover, their stories include examples of tension between teammates and perceived ruthlessness in their approach. Some shared how "in individual sport, one always wants to do the best for themselves and it is hard sometimes to think about the team." Indeed, as competitions approached and selection decisions were made during the qualification window, the limits of their relationships were tested, "They've got the same goals as I have, so why should I really help them?" From the stories told it appeared that some of cyclists believed that the coaches were happy to allow the competitiveness play out, "sometimes the trainer is very happy when a rider is very strong. So [they] say why should I say something? [They're] strong, [they're] going to make the team fast so it's good." Taken collectively, these thoughts and behaviors symbolize elements of the *performance* narrative well documented within the literature.

Beyond the illustrations of the *performance* narrative when storying experiences with their teammates, the narrative was also evident within the cyclists' descriptions of interactions with

their coaches and broader society during the qualification window. For example, their stories included themes of frustration at the coaches' decision making (e.g., selection), coach-coach conflict, and the coaches' philosophy; we interpreted this frustration as arising due to the cyclists' belief that the coaches were impeding their quest for success. To illustrate, the coaches' philosophy was characterized by several participants as being driven by coaches wanting the cyclist "to become the best person in the world that they can be," rather than the "best [cyclist] in the world," which was at odds with the performance template being followed by the cyclists, with one stating,

[Although] it's very nice because all the riders you find in Federation are all very nice people, in the end, in the sport, only the victory counts. And I would say the rider is going to be happier if [they] win in [their] career as a sportsperson, rather than being third or fifth but knowing that [they're] a better person.

The frustration experienced by the cyclists when others did not subscribe to the *performance* narrative was also driven by wider societal messages. In this instance, we interpreted that the lower societal value placed on sport outcomes and associated lack of recognition served to disregard the cyclists' commitment, and drew an agitated response,

As an athlete in [country], people say 'you're a sports-person but you don't really work. You don't know what it's like to wake up in the morning and go to work'. But they also don't know what it's like to be away from home 250 days per year and not having one weekend for you!

More broadly, the national sociocultural norms (i.e., to express gratitude and display humility) meant that the cyclists' stories were, at times, tempered in gravitas (i.e., less celebratory than may have been expected) and the display of the *performance* narrative was thus restrained. For example, when expressing pride in their performance, one cyclist stated "it's not very [nationality] to speak like that."

In contrast to the single-mindedness and ruthlessness storied by some of the cyclists when embracing the *performance* narrative, others' accounts privileged relationships and fun as the vehicle to winning and success. For example, when asked about the importance of their relationships on qualification performance, they spoke of how "performances are better in a team that gets on well with each other" and how the

relationships can indirectly influence performance, “at the end, I cannot say that [the relationships] bring better results, but [they] bring better mentality and more fun. And, I think the results come when you are happy and when you have fun.”

Finding enjoyment and having fun were also described as necessary to overcome the demands and the sense of obligatory sacrifices resulting from the *performance* narrative:

I think you need the joy beside what are you doing because otherwise, you wouldn't kill yourself in intervals or whatever. In these situations, you definitely need a goal and that's when the warrior is there and helps you, but without the joy, I wouldn't do that. I wouldn't be a professional athlete. You're away from home so much missing a lot, but I don't really care because I like what I'm doing. That's why joy helps me, how I get through.

The challenges and demands that impinged on the cyclists' love of the sport included the physical, emotional, and social costs of being away for long periods, difficulties with balancing cycling with other commitments, crashes, financial precarity, societal judgments, and the battle with self-doubt. For example, one cyclist highlighted the social sacrifices of making cycling your life “sometimes when you're at home ... you feel that you really live for cycling. You don't have any friends at home and not a lot of contacts outside of the sport, and sometimes; this hurts.” Others described the perceived commitments and demands associated with having to “live like a sportsperson” being incompatible with their private lives, how they found it “hard to have other life stress when I really need to be in the [mindset for] racing.” To mitigate these demands the cyclists emphasized how they wanted to ensure that they maintained the enjoyment that initially sparked their interest in the sport. To do this, they stressed the importance of trying to focus on the “present” rather than getting distracted with the future (e.g., the Olympics, retirement):

I understand that they [the coaches] think about it [the Olympics] and that the riders are thinking about it too, but I think that if you really want to enjoy what you're doing or take pleasure in the competition you are doing at the moment, you need to focus on what happens now and not on the [qualification] points that you do for next year.

Although some cyclists appeared to readily embrace the *performance* narrative within their stories, others were resistant to it and confronted the narrow identity it encouraged such as when describing how being seen “as a person” was “something of the most importance as we're not

machines.” There were also instances where the cyclists experienced conflict when the *performance* narrative silenced and replaced their alternative script. For example, during their second interview, one cyclist who engaged with their sport via a dual career scenario, stated that, “University is second priority all the time at the moment. But, actually, I don't want to be a person like that to say, oh, yes, school is not that important,” yet by the third interview they stated “Of course, I want good grades, but actually I just want to pass.” This shift in priority could be seen as indicative of a switch from a dual career narrative to the more dominant singular (sport) performance focus.

Discovery

The cyclists' stories documented the journeys they had already been on, along with those on which they continued to travel, during the Games qualification window. Within these stories, the cyclists had moments of confrontation, frustration, acceptance, resignation, and enlightenment. Collectively, these appeared to represent a narrative of *discovery*; a narrative in which, via moments of disruption and growth, the cyclists achieved clarity of thought and obtained new knowledge, skills, and/or belief. There were a breadth of stories featuring discovery told by the cyclists; here, we offer two types based on the nature of the journey that led to the discovery: confronting and enlightening.

The first type of *discovery* narrative related to stories which confronted already-held beliefs, such as the stories told when participants' initial belief that “we're qualified for sure” was challenged. This story began with success “when we did our first world cup season, we were so good, and so many top five results. We were like, oh, we own the world,” but this was later disrupted by the progress made by other nations “everyone is just improving so much. It's insane,” contrasted with that they had made as a team, “we never had better results than 2 years ago when we just started.” Ultimately, the surprise that characterized the early stages of this story resolved to a realization that “hey, we really need to work hard to even qualify for the Olympics.” A similar story of confrontation and discovery was told by participants about their thoughts on the “image of the great athlete's life” and the experience of big sporting events, with initial impressions replaced by the realization that an athlete's life is “not

glamour at all” and that the experience portrayed on social media is “a big show.”

The second discovery-based stories were those relating to a sense of enlightenment, which included experiences of growth in confidence and solace for participants. With regards to a growth in confidence, the cyclists storied how race experiences and results had led them to establish greater self-belief, “It [the race] was really hard, but I learned and now I hope that next year I will be more an actor in the race ... yes, I am confident. Now I see on the track I’m really more confident” and to move beyond a belief that they were “a one-hit-wonder.” For others, their experiences on and off the track during data collection evoked questioning, the resolution of which brought them to a state of peace. One participant expressed,

I think [their illness] makes me see that cycling is very important in my life, but it’s just a sport. It makes me realize that whether I succeed or not. If I have good result or not it’s not a big deal. Okay, I’m going to be disappointed but, at the end, it’s makes no difference ... before I was always thinking that [winning is] my main reason to be a cyclist and getting results was the most important thing, but not anymore.

Building on a similar discussion about a sense of growth, another cyclist went on to reflect,

“Cycling is just the best side thing you can do,” one of my old coaches always said that to me, and I never really got it. ... But now I get it. It’s a side thing. It’s not your life. It doesn’t define you if you’re a good person or not. The real people who like you don’t care if you have a gold medal or if you went to the Olympics or not.

While some of the stories underpinned by the *discovery* narrative took time to unfold, learning also occurred abruptly following a tragic accident involving some of the cyclists. The stories told at this time reflected the growth and realization of strength in the relationships between the participants. At this moment, the cyclists described how they practically and emotionally supported one another, as one cyclist reflected,

When something like that happens, I think it’s the perfect moment to be there for the other cyclists. ... we all stayed in this moment and pretty close and supportive to everyone and that was a good. ... We could see [at that moment] that the team’s spirit is there and it was better than in any [teambuilding] game you can do. It’s real life.

Vindication

This last narrative was reflected in the stories told by the cyclists who were on a journey of

proving their capabilities to themselves and others when performing on an international stage; this journey superseded other performative elements. The stories were rooted in previous successes that had enabled the cyclists to achieve and maintain selection in the international squad. Yet, recent events led these foundations to be questioned and shaken, and the cyclists were attempting to navigate this uncertainty and reestablish their own and others’ perceived belief in their place within the program.

Vindication stories typically began with the cyclist describing the difficulties they had faced and the psychological impacts that these had had. One cyclist described how, after failing to qualify for finals on consecutive days, they “doubted everything. I was like, what am I even doing here?” For another, they described experiencing “a lot of doubt and depression” and that they were “very angry with myself” after repeated poor results. Perhaps most pertinently, the cyclists described how they had begun to internalize these events, “I often take [being seen as a weaker cyclist] very personally. ... Not my performance is not good enough, me as a person is not good enough.”

Next within these narratives, the emotional loss and anger illustrated in the cyclists’ initial reactions was typically replaced by an acceptance of their situation, “the truth is sometimes difficult to hear,” and a desire to use it to create a shift in their experience,

When [cyclist] spoke about the team, [they] said, you are not so good and so I [don’t want to race with you]. And we were more motivated to get a good result without [them], and I think it was a really good thing. Because everybody wanted to show [them] that we can be fast without [them].

While some cyclists exuded an assertiveness in their desire to prove themselves and a rapid establishment of confidence when they felt this was achieved, “and after that, to do our personal best was really good for us. And we know we can ride fast ... and this was very important for us,” others were more hesitant and circumspect when presenting their argument. After initially describing being “so scared of racing. I was like, no, I don’t want to race, because I can’t handle another big disappointment,” one cyclist went on to detail how they had raced “actually quite good,” and how, by the end, they felt that they had “showed myself I can still ride quick.” Moreover, as the data collection progressed and results improved, although one still

described themselves as “the weakest” cyclist, there appeared to be a growing recognition that team selection may actually have more to do with how cyclists’ attributes complemented each other, “and I think [when selected alongside the other cyclists], I don’t know ... it just works quite well.”

It appeared within these *vindication* stories that the improving results and growing sense of confidence had a positive impact on the cyclists’ experiences with one participant stating how they felt the results made “life more meaningful,” that their coach and teammates now trusted them, and how, with the Tokyo Games on the horizon, they no longer felt they needed to prove themselves to others:

I have the feeling that if I fail, it’s not like I’ll accept it if I fail, but if I fail now, it’s okay, I think, because I did all I wanted to do to get to the Games. Now it’s just going to be the competition and I think I’m ready for it. I’m getting stressed because you get pressure from the competition itself, but I have less pressure now from showing them [coach, teammates, and general public] that I’m good. I wanted to show everybody because I’m an athlete and this is what I want, but I have nothing to prove anymore.

Collating Member Reflections

When sharing the realist tale with the cyclists and their coaches, the participants were asked to reflect on the emotions and thoughts they noticed when reading it, and any reflections they might choose to share should they enter the qualification cycle for the Paris Olympic Games. One coach described how the narratives provoked feelings of pride, happiness, and sadness. For example, they expressed how they felt “quite proud to have helped guide the riders through those difficult times” in the *discovery* narrative. The coach also confirmed the existence of conflict within the group and how “there are times when the coaches are happy to have a competitive environment,” while acknowledging that there were times when they perhaps “allowed [the competitive environment] to flourish a bit too much or a bit too regularly.” In hindsight, the coach said that the qualification environment could maybe have been “better controlled and thought through.” These reflections may be seen as contradicting the coaches’ messaging around personal development over performance, and perhaps reflect the coaches’ own battle with moving away from the *performance* narrative.

From the cyclists’ perspectives, the narratives evoked a comparison between their past experiences and their ongoing lived realities as they prepared for the Paris Olympiad. They described how “a lot of the quotes are similar to what it feels now,” perhaps indicative of the persistence and embeddedness of the narratives. But that their learnings from the Tokyo cycle meant they feel better prepared and more aware of what to expect for the Paris cycle, “I have more trust this time.” The reflections that the narratives evoked also included some persisting concerns, “I still think that the team is not the most self-confident nation,” and a continued hope to return to a previous relationship with their sport that was guided less by the performance narrative and more by enjoyment, so that they can “enjoy cycling for how it is and to be freer in my mind and achieve great results.”

Discussion

Our purpose for the present study was to explore elite track cyclists’ stories of attempting to experience thriving during an Olympic qualification window. More specifically, we hoped to describe the narratives underpinning the cyclists’ stories during this time and to gain an understanding of the sociocultural factors that were perceived to influence their experiences. Within our results, we have presented a realist tale of the narratives that underpinned the cyclists’ stories which included *performance*, *discovery*, and *vindication*. Taking each narrative in turn, the following discussion situates the narratives in existing literature before we then reflect on the impact of the findings for promoting thriving in practice.

The cyclists in this study frequently drew on the *performance* narrative within the stories they told. This reflects the pervasiveness of this sociocultural template in their experiences and aligns with the regularity and consistency that it appears within narrative work in elite sport populations (e.g., Carless & Douglas, 2013; Douglas & Carless, 2009; Franck & Stambulova, 2019). Yet, from the stories told by the cyclists, it was unclear how the performance narrative came to be the template used. Within the organization, the cyclists described how the coaches emphasized personal development over performance outcomes and, outside of the organization, how lower societal value was placed on sport outcomes. These details raise interesting questions about when the performance narrative became entrenched in the

experiences and perspectives of the participants, with the cyclists described having started cycling because they found it fun. Of course, the context of Games qualification is likely important and it featured heavily in the cyclists' stories. Indeed, the need to achieve results for qualification appeared to encourage some displays of single-mindedness and ruthlessness typically associated with the performance narrative. However, several of the cyclists' also shared stories that emphasized the importance of relationships and enjoyment in their pursuit of winning and success. Indeed, comparable to Ronkainen and Ryba's (2020) description of preelite athletes' desire to have a future identity as a performance, relational, and fun athlete, the cyclists emphasized the importance of friendships and how, without deep-seated enjoyment, they would not have persisted through the physical, social, and psychological demands of their sport. Altogether, these results reinforce the presence of the performance narrative, while also highlighting the importance of fun, enjoyment, and love for the sport in athletes' experiences.

Discovery and *vindication* narratives existed alongside the *performance* narrative in the stories told by the cyclists, whereby the *discovery* narrative provided a template to describe stories of learning or realizing something new, and the *vindication* narrative provided a structure to stories of proving one's credentials to oneself and others when performing on an international stage. The *discovery* narrative within the cyclists' stories, holds similarities to the discovery narrative described by Douglas and Carless (2006). For the cyclists sampled herein, for example, they storied how they discovered a new way of perceiving their sport and big sporting events. However, some deviations may also exist between the original and current *discovery* narratives, in that the cyclists' stories appeared to have a strong focus on discovery resulting in learning whereas Kandy's story in Douglas and Carless (2006) appears to focus more on discovery for experience and personal fulfillment. Turning to the *vindication* narrative, this appears to share similarities with the redemption narrative described by McGannon et al. (2023). To illustrate, both *vindication* and redemption appear to focus on rectifying a past mistake, failure, or wrongdoing. However, they are different in that redemption is a largely internally focused script of absolution of previous errors or mistakes, whereas the *vindication*

narrative is an externally focused script, driven by a desire to prove others wrong. *Vindication* also bears similarity to the restitution narrative (Frank, 1995), in that this vindication will lead to returning to a previous status or, in this study, one's return to a selection or qualification place.

Across the three narratives, several sociocultural features furnished the storied experiences of the cyclists including the relationships with their teammates and coaches, and the demands associated with elite level cycling. To elaborate on the relationships, it appeared that the exchanges with teammates and coaches fluctuated in levels of friction, rivalry, interdependence, and closeness during the qualification period. The association between the quality of these relationships (i.e., depth, sincerity, trust) and attempts to experience thriving echo previous findings in professional sport (Brown & Arnold, 2019) and data from organization-wide thriving interventions (Passaportis et al., 2022). Yet, other features such as the resistance to helping others elucidate the limits to these relations in high-performance settings and the difficulties that may exist when attempting to promote and sustain them over an Olympic qualification window. It appears important for practitioners to better prepare and support athletes to cope with these tensions that may arise within their relationships, and to raise organizational awareness of how and when friction may occur to enable the promotion of thriving at individual and collective levels.

Turning to the demands experienced, the cyclists storied how some of the challenges they were experiencing during the qualification window (e.g., social isolation) hindered their experiences of thriving by thwarting their enjoyment and sense of social connection. Others spoke of how the demands created stress and how, ultimately, cycling became more like a job than a passion. The demanding nature of elite sport during qualification has been previously documented (see, Mitchell et al., 2021), as have the suggested links between encountering stressors and thriving via stress appraisal (Brown, Arnold, Fletcher, & Standage, 2017; Brown, Arnold, et al., 2021). What appears particularly interesting here is how these accounts may have been influenced by sociocultural norms; specifically, the cyclists' reluctance to complain about the challenges. In future research, it would be interesting to better understand whether these norms were directly impacting the appraisals made by the

cyclists (e.g., cyclists have been socialized to interpret demands as being less stressful) or the manner in which the cyclists reported their experience (e.g., tempered their story to fit with the dominant narrative). For practitioners, it may be useful to understand the sociocultural setting in which they are working to better negotiate conversations with athletes about how they are *truly* coping with the demands, rather than how the athletes believe they *should* be coping.

Illuminating the narratives that underpinned the athletes' stories of attempting to experience thriving during Olympic qualification and the sociocultural features that characterized these experiences provides important insight for athletes, their coaches, and the support staff that assist them. Yet, our results also pose questions for coaching and management staff. First, staff might reflect on when it is best to evaluate qualification campaign trajectory and they should provide clarity on this to their athletes. In the interviews, the cyclists' storied their changing evaluation of progress and the alarm they experienced when they realized their trajectory toward Olympic qualification had changed. It follows that establishing, communicating, and remaining consistent on information regarding how staff intend to evaluate campaign success will help manage athlete expectations. Such actions would also likely be beneficial for staff as they consider how to tailor support to their athletes whose campaigns are following different trajectories (e.g., discovery vs. vindication). Second, it appeared to us from the narratives underpinning the cyclists' stories and the different relationships that the cyclists had with the narratives, that no two individuals were on the same path nor had identical preferences. Thus, although idiosyncratic approaches may make it difficult to create a uniform environment that enables common thriving across the group, careful use of discretion may allow the formation of varying individual environments to support each athlete's needs (see [Passaportis et al., 2022](#)), and, ultimately, the experience of collective thriving as an integrated squad (cf. [McGuire et al., 2025](#)). Third, the existence of a *vindication* narrative within the cyclists' stories leads us to suggest that practitioners may seek ways to help coaches and senior leaders to reflect on how they can mitigate against the need for vindication, perhaps by raising awareness of the potential for other narratives and minimizing the perspective that thriving ensues from adversity.

Potential Limitations and Recommendations for Future Research

In this work, we sought to understand the narratives underpinning the experiences of elite track cyclists and, therefore, limited our exploration to the experiences of only one group of individuals (i.e., the athletes) operating within the sporting organization. During 6 months of data collection, the first author developed a strong rapport with both the cyclists and the wider members of the organization, and observed how the changing demands of the qualification window also influenced those beyond the athletes. Although these observations were noted in the researcher's reflective journal, a dedicated study of the narratives reflected in the stories of coaches and support staff during this phase of the quadrennial cycle would likely provide critical insight for understanding the experiences of these other groups, and how thriving can be promoted across the organization. Moreover, having an awareness of the shared and divergent narratives held within an organization would provide researchers and practitioners with a fuller picture of the sociocultural templates that both coaches and athletes bring to their interactions and experiences. Such knowledge could serve to create a shared understanding of the diversity of experience within and between organizational subgroups.

The project should be viewed through an observational lens and not read or understood as an attempt to instigate change. It is true that the first author's presence and interactions with the athletes and staff at the training camps and competitions may have influenced the cyclists' experiences (e.g., altered conversation topics over lunch), but he attempted to hold a passive position whereby he tried not to make suggestions or recommendations. Thus, no interventions for promoting thriving were explicitly tested and the aforementioned practical implications will warrant further exploration in future research.

Conclusions

This study was conducted amid a growing shift in the narratives that inform athletes' experiences in sport. More specifically, within research and practice, attempts are being made to replace the prevailing *performance* narrative with one that advocates for the concurrent experience of sporting success and athlete welfare. The findings from

this study suggest that this transition still has far to go and that the *performance* narrative is still prominent within many, if not all, athlete experiences. Moreover, our results also show that this transition will be complex, with fun and enjoyment currently storied as routes to achieve performance outcomes, rather than important and worthwhile outcomes with their own merit. It thus remains to be seen whether the *performance* narrative can be replaced by a *thriving* counter-narrative that emphasizes athlete well-being and welfare alongside performance.

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